

17 L.A. Hill

Leslie A. Hill was British Council's Chief Education Officer for India and in this capacity made significant contribution to English Language Teaching in India. He has written several books in this field. He prepared a 3275 head-word vocabulary and in accordance with that he prepared the textbook *A Prelude to English* (1969) from which the present essay 'Principles of Good Writing' has been taken.

Principles of Good Writing

To write well, you have to be able to write clearly and logically, and you cannot do this unless you can think clearly and logically too. If you cannot do this yet, you should train yourself to do it by taking particular problems and following them through, point by point, to a solution, without leaving anything out and without avoiding any difficulties that you meet.

For example, you may take the problem, 'What do I mean when I say that I am a free person?' and then try to find a solution along something like the following lines: 'Am I free to do anything I like? No, I am not free to fly to Mars, for example. My freedom is limited to what is possible. Am I then free to do anything that it is possible for me to do? No, I am not free to kill my neighbour, for example. My freedom is limited to what is possible and legal. But am I not in fact free to kill my neighbour provided I can do it without being found out? Well, yes, in fact I am. My freedom is therefore limited to what is possible and legal, unless I can avoid being found out in something illegal. Why are there legal

limitations to my freedom? Because if I were free to do harm to others, thereby limiting their freedom, they too would be free to do me harm; and under these conditions, I would have a less chance of freedom than if I and everybody else accepted certain legal limitations on our freedom in order to protect the latter against arbitrary interference by others. Etc.'

At first, you may find clear, step-by-step thought very difficult. You may find that your mind continually wanders. But practice will improve your ability to think clearly and logically.

In order to increase your vocabulary and to improve your powers of expression, you should read widely and carefully, and keep a notebook in which to write down words and expressions that particularly strike you; for example, *sparkle*, *glitter*, *twinkle*, *blaze*, *gleam*, etc. Use a good dictionary to help you with the exact meanings and uses of words.

Always remember that regular and frequent practice is essential if you are to learn to write well. You learn to write by writing. It is no good waiting until you have an inspiration before you write. Even with the most famous writers, inspiration is rare. Writing is 99 per cent hard work and 1 percent inspiration, so the sooner you get into the habit of disciplining yourself to write, the better.

If you keep your eyes and ears open, you will find plenty of things to write about around you. Often a little piece of conversation heard in the street can start you thinking along interesting new lines. Imagine that you are a stranger who is not familiar with the things that you see around you, and start from there.

Read the newspaper carefully. Every day there are examples of human joy and human tragedy in it which can give you ideas for articles, essays or short stories.

Keep a notebook in which to put down things that you notice, or ideas that come to you when you are out walking, when you are reading a book or a magazine, or at any other time. Some people get ideas in the bath, or when they wake up during the night. Unless they write these ideas down at once, they often forget them.

Try to develop a warm, human understanding of people, their problems, their joys and their sorrows, so that you are genuinely interested in everyone you meet and every incident you see. You

will then find material for your work as a writer where before you could perhaps see nothing of interest.

To be a successful writer, you must write interestingly; but different kinds of people have different interests, and it is most unlikely that you will be able to appeal to all of them. You therefore have to know exactly what type of reader you are writing for, and exactly what kinds of things interest such a reader.

By carefully reading magazines which are written for particular kinds of readers (e.g. women's magazines, magazines for teenagers, magazines for well-educated men), you can find out the things that interest particular types of readers.

Most people are interested in the present. Even when they read about the past or the future, it is the latter's connections with, or relevance to, the present that particularly interests them. You should therefore choose subjects of topical interest—the latest fashions in some particular field, problems which worry people nowadays, and so on. You should write about Christmas when people are making preparations for this festival, and about summer holidays when the summer is approaching.

As much as possible, choose subjects of which you have personal experience. You will be able to write on these much more convincingly and with greater authority than on subjects about which you have only second-hand information.

Presentation is of very great importance in good writing. Your opening paragraph should arrest the reader's attention and show him what you are writing about and why. If you are going to give the reader some information, tell him what subject you are going to deal with. If you are going to argue in support of a particular point of view say what this point of view is. There is no harm in startling the reader in this first paragraph by putting forward a new and apparently paradoxical point of view, provided you have convincing arguments to support it in the rest of what you write.

The main body of your piece of writing should collect together and present the ideas promised in the first paragraph, or give good arguments to support the view put forward there. You should come to the point at once, say what you promised to say, avoiding irrelevant material, and then finish.

Your last paragraph or sentence should bring what you have written to a neat, satisfying end, leaving the reader with a clear idea of what you have been saying.

To write interestingly, you must yourself be intensely interested in what you are writing, and you must convey this feeling of eagerness to your readers. You must also believe intensely in what you are writing, and convince your readers of your honesty. You cannot arouse their interest and sympathy unless they feel that you yourself are interested, and that you feel strongly about what you are saying.

Do not, however, force upon the reader those of your own private problems which few, if any, other people share. People are very interested in problems which they too face, or which they may easily have to face in the near future, but they do not want to read the personal complainings and protests of someone whom they consider a crank, or whom they suspect of being mentally unbalanced.

Do not strive to create an impression. Forget about yourself, think only of the reader, and write naturally, avoiding self-consciousness. If you have something interesting to write about and can express it clearly simply and with the human touch, it is sure to appeal to some classes of readers. But if you deliberately try to copy a style which is not your own, this will quickly become obvious to the reader, he will feel that you are not sincere, and he will not go on reading what you have written. As you read more and more works written in a particular style, your own will gradually change; but this will be a natural process, and your new style will be yours, because it comes up from your unconscious, unlike a style which you are deliberately copying.

This does not mean that you should not cultivate vivid expression. If you train yourself to see and hear things keenly and responsively, as an artist or a musician does, you will be able to describe them vividly yet without artificiality.

It is best to write simply and in a conversational tone. Clean, plain English is the fashion these days, and an elaborate, decorated style is quite out of date. Avoid jargon (e.g. *re your letter to hand* meaning 'with reference to the letter which I have received from

you') and officialese (e.g. *it is apprehended that* meaning 'I suppose'), hackneyed expressions (e.g. *Adam's ale* for 'water' and *do one's level best* for 'do the best one can'), rhetorical flourishes (e.g. *This is a subject of great importance to many people nowadays, and therefore one which I feel I should discuss seriously and honestly*). The reader knows whether he thinks it important or not; and he certainly does not need to be told that, if it is of great importance, it deserves to be discussed seriously and honestly), empty verbiage (e.g. *I feel obliged to add that, doubtless, many people appreciate that it is a matter of the greatest importance that information about possible cases of cruelty to children should be passed on to the appropriate authorities immediately*, in which the first 20 words are empty verbiage) and circumlocutions (e.g. *I will cause investigations to be made with a view to ascertaining the information*, instead of 'I will find out').

Prefer the concrete to the abstract word whenever possible, be definite, call a spade a spade, and avoid euphemisms. The latter have been called the Cult of Cosiness, which means the pretence that everything is all right when it is not. In Hitler's Germany, for example, the expression *special treatment* was used as a euphemism for torture and murder of the most savage kinds.

Here is an example, taken from Dickens' novel *David Copperfield*, of the sort of things to avoid:

My dear Sir,

Years have elapsed, since I had an opportunity of ocularly perusing the lineaments, now familiar to the imaginations of a considerable portion of the civilised world. But, my dear sir, though estranged (by the force of circumstances over which I have had no control) from the personal society of the friend and companion of my youth, I have not been unmindful of his soaring flight. Nor have I been debarred from participating in the intellectual feasts he has spread before us.

I cannot, therefore, allow of the departure from this place of an individual whom we mutually respect and esteem, without, my dear sir, taking this public opportunity of thanking you, on my own behalf, and, I may undertake to add, on that of the whole of

the inhabitants of Port Middlebay, for the gratification of which you are the ministering agent.

Go on, my dear sir! You are not unknown here, you are not unappreciated. Though 'remote', we are neither 'unfriended', 'melancholy', nor (I may add) 'slow'. Go on, my dear sir, in your eagle course! The inhabitants of Port Middlebay may at least aspire to watch it, with delight, with entertainment, with instruction! Among the eyes elevated towards you from this end of the globe, will ever be found, while it has light and life,

The Eye Appertaining to Wilkins Micawber, Magistrate.

We should now write, instead of the above, something like this:

Dear Sir,

It is many years since I last had an opportunity to see you, and you have now become famous throughout a considerable part of the civilised world. Although circumstances beyond my control have made it impossible for me to continue the close association with you which I enjoyed in my youth, I have followed your progress and read your books with great pleasure.

Now that you are leaving Port Middlebay, I would therefore like to thank you, on my own behalf and on behalf of the inhabitants of this town, for the pleasure you have given us, and to wish you even greater success in the future.

Yours faithfully, etc.

Avoid stating the obvious; e.g. your readers do not want to be told that aeroplanes sometimes crash, or that children learn from their parents as well as from their teachers.

Use the same style throughout whatever you are writing. If you are writing formally, do not introduce slang expressions; and if you are writing in a conversational style, do not introduce literary or learned expressions. A mixture of styles, such as the following is absurd: 'In the absence, on home leave, of my boss, your application

for sympathetic consideration of your claim to a pension has been pushed on to me. I have had no alternative but to give it the thumbs down, owing to the fact that your old man had ceased to be in the service of Her Majesty when he kicked the bucket.'

If, while you are writing you cannot think of the right word at once, it is a good idea to put in another, or to leave a blank, so as not to interrupt your flow of thought. Then, when you have finished, you can go back and find exactly the right word for what you were trying to say.

In any case, read your work over critically after you have finished it, replacing 'weak, vague, inexact words by others which say just what you mean.

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About the Essay

In 'Principles of Good Writing' L.A. Hill discusses the fundamentals of writing well. He suggests that one of the prerequisites of writing with clarity is the ability to think logically. Everyone may not possess this ability in equal measure. With discipline, however, minds can be taught to focus and to think logically. Written expression can also be improved with the help of a good vocabulary which, in turn, can be increased by reading widely. Keeping a notebook for recording new words and expressions is another useful habit. Ideas which occur to us at odd moments and unusual places slip out of our minds unless they are recorded immediately in a notebook.

Hill insists that one learns to write only by practising writing. As is true of most other skills, inspiration alone is not enough to produce a well-written piece of work. Besides, one cannot rely on inspiration: it is not something that comes easily or often. Good writing is achieved mainly through discipline and diligence rather than random bursts of inspiration.

In order to succeed as a writer, it is also important to identify one's readers and to choose subjects which promise to be of interest to the selected readership. On the question of subjects, Hill argues that it is important for writers to be genuinely interested in what they are writing about; when writers have no personal experience of their chosen subjects, they cannot sound convincing to their readers and this detracts from the quality of their writing.

Good writing also benefits from good presentation. An opening paragraph which arrests the attention of the reader, and a closing paragraph which concludes the subject satisfactorily are signs of a well-presented piece of writing. Hill lays a lot of emphasis on a writing style which comes naturally to the writer. He argues that a simple, plain and conversational style is preferable to an elaborate and decorative style, which can seem artificial.

As someone who practices what he preaches, Hill's own style of writing is unaffected. By following the suggestions made in this essay, one can significantly improve the style and quality of one's writing.

In this essay tips of good writing are crystal clear and logical writing stems from logical thinking. Deep thinking on any subject brings clarity about the subject and the ideas put systematically with the help of apt vocabulary result in good writing. It is essential to keep our eyes, ears open to write about the things around us. Reading the newspaper daily with care and keeping a note book are the essential ingredients. A writer must take care of people's interest and present the points absorbingly. He must not put his personal problems into writing. He must avoid jargons, officialese, hackneyed expressions, the farcical flourishes, empty verbiage etc. must be avoided and clean, plain English should be used in order to make writing effective and powerful.

Glossary

arbitrary: which is not based on laws which have been democratically voted.

butcher-blue: of the same colour as the blue stripes on a butcher's apron. There is also the suggestion that it is a cold, heartless blue, because a butcher's job is cold and heartless.

jargon: language which is ugly or difficult to understand because it is unnecessarily technical.

officialese: the special jargon used by government officials

hackneyed: used so often that people are bored with them.

rhetorical: artificial and or exaggerated.

verbiage: a lot of unnecessary words

circumlocutions: using a lot of words to say something that can be said in a few words.

euphemisms: the opposite of calling a spade a spade; i.e., using polite, vague words in place of the plain, direct ones because the latter might shock people.

- the cult of*: being devoted to; being a strong believer in.
cosiness: being warm and comfortable, either physically, or mentally.
ocularly: with (my) eyes.
perusing: reading carefully
lineaments: features (of the face)
unmindful: forgetful
gratification: giving pleasure.
ministering: who does the action mentioned
appertaining: belonging
slang: language used in very informal conversation and letters, but not suitable for more formal occasions or for use in most types of writing.
give it the thumbs down: a slang expression meaning 'reject it.'
old man: a slang expression for 'husband'
kicked the bucket: a slang expression for 'died'